

PRIME LOCAL GROWTH

The Google Business Blueprint

The complete system for getting your local business into Google's top 3 results — without paying for ads.

Level: Beginner–Intermediate

Time to implement: 2–4 hours

Results timeline: 2–4 weeks

Before you start: This blueprint works best if you have access to your Google Business Profile. If you haven't claimed it yet, go to **business.google.com** and claim your listing first — it takes about 10 minutes. Everything in this guide builds on an active, claimed profile.

1

The GBP Audit — Find Every Gap

Google ranks businesses based on completeness, relevance, and activity. Most businesses are missing easy wins in their profile settings. Run through this checklist first — every unchecked box is leaving ranking on the table.



Business name matches exactly

Your GBP name must match your real-world signage, website, and other directories. No keyword stuffing ("Best Plumber San Antonio Plumbing Co.") — Google penalizes this.



Primary category is correct

This is your single most important ranking signal. Choose the most specific category available (e.g. "HVAC Contractor" not just "Contractor").

-
- ☐ **Secondary categories added**
Add 3–5 secondary categories that reflect all your services. Each category opens you up to more search queries.
-
- ☐ **Business description is complete (750 chars)**
Uses your primary keyword in the first sentence. Written naturally. No keyword lists.
-
- ☐ **Address or service area is accurate**
If you serve customers at their location, switch to a Service Area Business and list your coverage area.
-
- ☐ **Phone number is local, not 800**
Local numbers outperform toll-free for local search.
-
- ☐ **Website URL is correct and working**
Double-check this — broken website links hurt ranking.
-
- ☐ **Hours are complete and accurate**
Include special hours for holidays. Profiles with missing hours rank lower.
-
- ☐ **Services list is fully built out**
Add every service you offer with a name, description, and price (if applicable). Each service is a ranking opportunity.
-
- ☐ **Products section used (if applicable)**
Product listings add content to your profile and attract more views.
-
- ☐ **Attributes are filled in**
Check "More" → attributes. Options vary by category — fill in everything that applies.
-
- ☐ **Messaging is enabled**
Allows customers to message you directly. Google rewards profiles that engage.
-
- ☐ **Booking link added**
If you use any booking software, link it here.
-
- ☐ **At least 10 photos uploaded**
Include exterior, interior, team, work examples, and your logo.

Quick win: The Services section is the most underused feature on GBP. Businesses that fully build out their services list see an average 15–25% increase in profile views within 30 days.

2

Keyword Strategy — Get Found for the Right Searches

Google matches search queries to GBP profiles based on how relevant your profile text is. You need to use the exact words your customers type — not industry jargon.

How to find your keywords

Open a browser in incognito mode. Search for your service + your city. Write down the top 10 results' business names and what categories they're listed under. These are your target keywords.

Examples by industry:

Industry	Primary keyword	Secondary keywords
HVAC	HVAC contractor [city]	AC repair, furnace installation, air conditioning service
Plumbing	Plumber [city]	drain cleaning, water heater repair, emergency plumber
Dental	Dentist [city]	teeth cleaning, dental implants, emergency dental, family dentist
Landscaping	Landscaping company [city]	lawn care, sprinkler repair, landscape design, sod installation
Cleaning	House cleaning service [city]	maid service, deep cleaning, move-out cleaning, commercial cleaning

Where to use your keywords

**Business description — first sentence**

"We are [city]'s trusted [primary keyword]..." Don't force it — write naturally but lead with the keyword.

**Service names and descriptions**

Name each service exactly how customers search for it.

**Google Posts**

Use your top 2–3 keywords naturally in every post.

**Review responses**

When responding to reviews, use keywords naturally ("Thanks for trusting us with your AC repair!").

**Q&A answers**

Answer questions using your keywords. You can post your own Q&As.

Do not: Stuff keywords unnaturally into your business name or description. Google's spam filters catch this and can suspend your listing entirely.

3

Business Description — Write One That Ranks

Your description is 750 characters and most businesses waste it. Here's the formula that works:

- **Sentence 1:** What you do + where (lead keyword)
- **Sentence 2–3:** What makes you different / your experience
- **Sentence 4:** Services you offer (secondary keywords)
- **Sentence 5:** Service area
- **Sentence 6:** Call to action

EXAMPLE — HVAC CONTRACTOR

"We are San Antonio's trusted HVAC contractor, providing fast, reliable heating and cooling services for homeowners and businesses since 2009. Our licensed technicians are available

7 days a week for same-day service. We specialize in AC repair, furnace installation, air conditioning maintenance, and emergency HVAC service across San Antonio, Schertz, and the surrounding areas. Call us today for a free estimate — most repairs completed same day."

EXAMPLE — DENTAL OFFICE

"Looking for a trusted dentist in Austin? Our family dental practice has been serving the Austin community for over 15 years, offering comprehensive care for patients of all ages. Services include routine cleanings, teeth whitening, dental implants, Invisalign, and emergency dental care. We accept most major insurance plans and offer flexible financing. Conveniently located in North Austin — accepting new patients now."



Photo Optimization — What Google's Algorithm Rewards

Profiles with 10+ photos receive 42% more direction requests and 35% more website clicks than profiles with no photos. Here's exactly what to upload:

Photo type	Quantity	What it signals to Google
Exterior (building/sign)	3–5	Confirms physical location exists
Interior	3–5	Establishes legitimacy and trust
Team / staff	2–4	Humanizes the business — improves engagement
Work examples / before & after	5–10	Demonstrates expertise and activity
Logo (cover photo)	1	Brand recognition in search results
Products or equipment	2–4	Reinforces service category signals

Technical requirements

- ☐ **File format:**
JPG or PNG
- ☐ **Minimum size:**
720×720px. Larger is better (up to 5MB).
- ☐ **Name your files before uploading**
File names like "hvac-repair-san-antonio.jpg" add a keyword signal. Generic names like "IMG_4027.jpg" do not.
- ☐ **No stock photos**
Google can identify stock images and they carry zero ranking weight.
- ☐ **Add new photos monthly**
Regular photo uploads signal an active business — a direct ranking factor.

Pro tip: After uploading photos, go back 2–3 days later and "like" or engage with any customer-uploaded photos. This signals activity on your profile and keeps your engagement rate high.

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Google Posts — Your 30-Day Activation Plan

Google Posts are mini-blog posts that appear directly on your profile. They expire after 7 days (offer posts) or stay up until you delete them. Businesses that post consistently rank higher — Google treats posting frequency as an activity signal.

Post types and when to use them

Post type	Best for	Include
Update	Tips, announcements, company news	Keyword-rich text, call to action, photo

Offer	Discounts, seasonal promotions	Start/end date, promo code, redemption link
Event	Open houses, webinars, local events	Date, time, location, description

30-day copy-and-paste post schedule

Replace **[CITY]**, **[SERVICE]**, and **[BUSINESS NAME]** with your own details.

WEEK 1 — INTRODUCTION POST

"Looking for reliable [SERVICE] in [CITY]? [BUSINESS NAME] has been serving [CITY] homeowners and businesses for [X] years. We specialize in [service 1], [service 2], and [service 3] — all with same-day availability and upfront pricing. Call us today for a free estimate. 📞 [PHONE]"

WEEK 2 — TIP / EDUCATIONAL POST

"[CITY] homeowners: here's one thing you can do right now to [prevent a common problem related to your service]. [Share a 2–3 sentence tip]. Need professional help? [BUSINESS NAME] is available 7 days a week. Call [PHONE] or message us here."

WEEK 3 — SOCIAL PROOF POST

"We just wrapped up a [project type] for a family in [NEIGHBORHOOD/CITY]. [1–2 sentences describing the job and result]. Our team takes pride in every job — no matter the size. Check out our reviews to see what our customers say, or give us a call at [PHONE]."

WEEK 4 — OFFER POST

"This month only: [BUSINESS NAME] is offering [specific offer — e.g. \$50 off your first service call / free inspection with any repair] for [CITY] residents. Limited availability. Call [PHONE] or click below to book. Offer expires [DATE]."

Posting cadence: Post once per week minimum. Twice per week is ideal. Use your phone — GBP posts take 5 minutes and the Google Maps app makes it easy to post on the go.

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Q&A Setup — Capture "Near Me" Searches

The Q&A section of your GBP is publicly editable — anyone can ask (or answer) questions. Most businesses ignore this, which means your competitors' customers or random people might be answering questions about your business incorrectly.

Step 1: Seed your own Q&As

Log in to your GBP, go to the Q&A section, and ask the following questions yourself (from a personal Google account, not the business account), then answer them from your business account:

- "Do you offer free estimates?"
- "What areas do you serve?"
- "Are you licensed and insured?"
- "How quickly can you respond to an emergency?"
- "What forms of payment do you accept?"
- "Do you offer any discounts or seasonal promotions?"

Use keywords naturally in your answers. Each answer is indexed by Google and can appear for relevant search queries.

Step 2: Monitor weekly

Google will notify you when new questions are asked. Answer every question within 24 hours. Unanswered questions hurt your engagement score.

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Service Area & Category Strategy

Service area setup

If you go to customers (plumber, HVAC, landscaper, cleaner, etc.), set your profile as a Service Area Business. Add every city, neighborhood, and zip code you serve. Google ranks you in the map pack for searches in those areas.

Important: Don't hide your address if you have a physical location — hiding your address removes you from the "near me" pack for your immediate area.

Category selection strategy

Your primary category is the #1 ranking factor in your GBP. Choose the most specific category that matches your core service. Add secondary categories for every additional service line.

What you do	Primary category	Secondary categories to add
HVAC	HVAC Contractor	Air Conditioning Contractor, Furnace Repair Service, Heating Contractor
General Plumbing	Plumber	Drainage Service, Water Heater Installer, Septic System Service
General Dentist	Dentist	Cosmetic Dentist, Dental Implants Periodontist, Teeth Whitening Service
House Cleaning	House Cleaning Service	Commercial Cleaning Service, Janitorial Service, Window Cleaning Service



Monthly Maintenance Checklist

Once your profile is optimized, keep it alive with this monthly routine. Takes 30–45 minutes per month.

- ☐ **Post 4 Google Posts**
(1 per week). Rotate between update, tip, proof, and offer.
- ☐ **Upload 2–4 new photos**

Fresh photos = active profile = higher ranking.

**Respond to all new reviews**

Both positive and negative. See the Review Generation Blueprint for templates.

**Answer any new Q&As**

Check the Q&A section for unanswered questions.

**Verify hours are current**

Update for holidays, seasonal changes, or staff changes.

**Check insights**

Review your profile views, search queries, and direction requests. Look for trends.

**Search yourself incognito**

Search "[your service] [your city]" and note your ranking position. Track monthly.

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